

Damage CONTROL

After setbacks in the Lok Sabha and local elections, the Left Front is pulling out all stops to stem the rot

[By Abhijit Dasgupta]

The writing has been on the wall long enough, but the Left Front Government is finally beginning to read it. The back-to-back defeats in the Lok Sabha and local elections and the dual fiascos of Nandigram and Singur have compelled the Left Government to get into a damage control mode in an attempt to stem the rot before the coalition faces its next acid test in two years—elections to the state Assembly.

Last week, Chief Minister Buddhadeb Bhattacharya made dramatic changes in the Cabinet, clipping the wings of his number three minister, Suryakanta Mishra, who has been relieved from the Panchayat Ministry that he headed for 13 years. The portfolio will now be held by Anisur Rahman, who was the animal resources minister. Left Front Chairman Biman Bose tried to camouflage the shake-up saying Mishra was “under too much pressure of work and we needed to lighten his burden”. But it is not lost on anybody that Rahman, an old party hand, belongs to the minority community, a votebank that the Left needs to win back if it is to arrest its slide into oblivion.

With the power crisis becoming another sore point for the Government, old-time power minister Mrinal Banerjee too has been shed of his additional charge, the labour ministry. He has been asked to focus only on the power sector. Of late, the power cuts in some areas have lasted

for six hours a day. With Durga Puja coming up, the Government would rather not have the power ministry worry about labour too. The ministry will now be headed by Anadi Sahu, a minister of state in the same ministry earlier.

The week also saw about 60,000 polluting vehicles being taken off the road in Kolkata following a court order which the state Government ensured was followed strictly. The move has won praises for the Left at a time when the Mamata Banerjee juggernaut is picking up speed. Its efforts have been lauded by the media and other critics who are calling it “a major step in cleaning the environment”.

With the results of both Lok Sabha and local elections proving that the rural masses have begun to move away from its fold, the Left Front Government is unveiling plans to bring them back. The state Government's first tentative step towards this direction centres around the issue of land purchase. At a recent cabinet committee meeting, the Left decided that land acquisition in the future would be given a “human face”. The decision made it clear that all land earmarked for new embankments to be built in the cyclone-hit Sunderbans area will be purchased directly from the farmers, and not through the usual, time-consuming bureaucratic process. According to Abdur Rezzak Mollah, the land and land reforms minister, the embankments built years ago were folding up like cards under the impact of tidal



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waves. “I have requested the Irrigation Department to look into the matter and ensure that the dams across 3,500 km of the Sunderbans be built on land purchased directly from the villagers,” he says.

The cabinet committee headed by Rezzak included Irrigation Minister Subhas Naskar and Sunderbans Affairs Minister Kanti Ganguly. It recommended the land be purchased directly from the farmers so that the money can reach the affected farmers straightaway and without unnecessary delay. The Trinamool Congress is also supporting the decision. “As long as the industries are not allowed to flourish at the cost of the farmland, we have nothing to say,” says Union Minister of State for Rural